The imposition of Hindi has long been a hot-button issue in the south, especially in Tamil Nadu. The DK and its successor parties (the DMK and AIADMK), were opposed to making Hindi mandatory in schools as far back as 1937. Anna (as he was popularly known) was even imprisoned for his participation in the 1937 protests—it would not be the last time he was jailed over the issue.

Seeking political power

In 1949, Anna parted ways with Periyar over differences of opinion on both personal and ideological issues. Along with several other DK members, Anna then founded the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). The DMK harnessed the power of cinema, theatre and journalism as well as public conferences to take the party's message to the public. The party's membership grew at an astonishing rate through the 1950s, and it soon became one of India's strongest regional parties. In 1962, Anna was nominated to the Rajya Sabha, but his biggest moment came in 1967, when he took office as chief minister of Tamil Nadu. His tenure was brief, but his government's policies were aimed at social reform and inclusive growth—among the measures he introduced were free pre-university education for the poor, the legalization of self-respect marriages (conducted without priests) and increased reservations in jobs and education.

